

Liberators Network #3: Your Impact As A Scrum Practitioner

Create transparency around your impact with Scrum and how you can do more



Hey there Liberator!

We can tell you from experience how rewarding it is to start communities. Whether it is a regional Liberator meetup or a community in your organization, it is such a great way to give people a place where they can give *and* get help from peers on the challenges they face.

But how do you start? In this series, we share our most successful strings for starting meetups, initiatives, and communities. We know from experience that they work, are fun to facilitate, and put a smile on people's faces. In other words, you can rely on these strings to get started!

With the instructions in this guide, you should be able to run this workshop smoothly. But if you need help, we can also facilitate this workshop with you remotely. Contact us at info@theliberators.com for availability and pricing.

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Flow



Step 1: Opening

 2 min

Step 2: Clarify The Purpose Of Scrum With 10x10 Writing



 15 min

Step 3: Explore The Worst Possible Impact With TRIZ



 25 min

Step 4: Give & Get Help With Helping Heuristics



 45 min

Step 5: Closing

 3 min

Total duration

 90 min

The Purpose Of This String



In the previous strings, we created psychological safety and clarified the purpose of your group. The purpose of this third string is a more personal one; what is the impact you create as a Scrum practitioner?

About Impact and Purpose

The Scrum Framework exists to help you, your team, and your organization to better navigate the risks that are inherent to uncertain and complex work. It does so by giving you a basic outline where you work in small steps towards a larger objective, measuring your progress along the way. All the elements of the framework – the roles, events, and artifacts – serve that purpose.

No matter how appealing that purpose sounds, it is easy to forget about it in the daily challenges Scrum Teams face. Product Owners can easily forget to gather feedback from actual stakeholders in their drive to add "just a few more features". Scrum Masters can spend most of their Sprints preparing awesome Sprint Retrospectives while forgetting about the larger impediments plaguing their team. Development Teams easily lose sight of the need to release frequently over their desire to add all sorts of nice bells and whistles. Although all of this happens for understandable reasons, it limits the ability of teams to work empirically.

We designed this string to help Scrum practitioners reflect on their impact on the empirical process that underlies the Scrum Framework. For some, this string can be a hard wake-up call that they've been focusing on the wrong things. For others, it will be a confirmation that they're going in the right direction.



How To Prepare



Group Size

This string of Liberating Structures is feasible from 4 participants and onward. We've successfully scaled it up to 100 participants (both virtually and in-person) without significant issues.

Intended Audience

We designed this string with Scrum practitioners in mind. So Scrum Masters, Product Owners, Agile Coaches, and other members of Scrum Teams are prime candidates. But you can easily replace "Scrum" with what matters most to your group, like "Liberating Structures", "Social diversity" or "High-quality code".

Virtual Delivery

Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

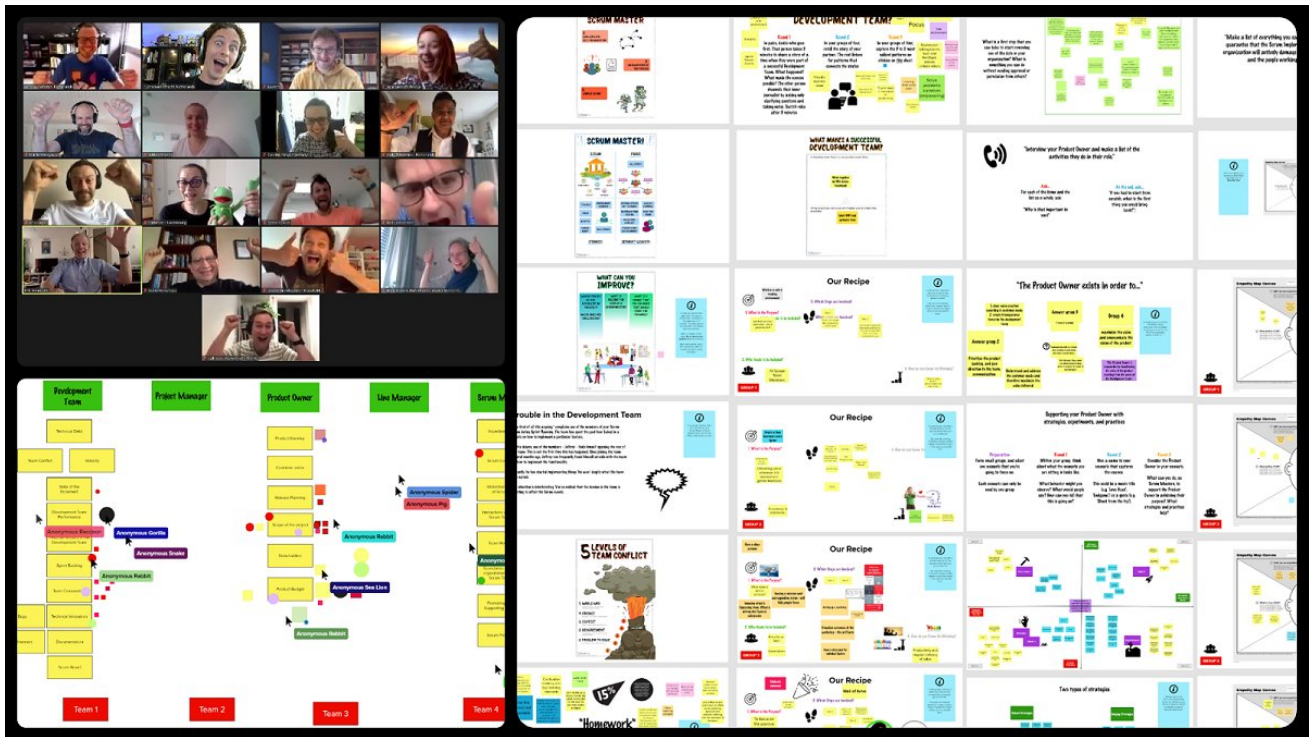
Material

- Optionally, [The Liberators Meetup Starter Kit](#) that patrons in the "Liberator"-tier receive for free
- This [visualization of the Scrum Framework](#) is useful when talking about the purpose of the Scrum Framework.
- For Helping Heuristics, it is helpful to create a slide or workspace where the rounds and steps are briefly outlined so that participants have something to fall back to. Refer to [this](#) or [this](#) article for an outline.

Resources

- Whitepaper: [Scrum: A Framework to Reduce Risk and Deliver Sooner](#)
- Blogpost and research: [How do Scrum Masters Deal With Problems Outside of Their Team's Control](#)





2 min

Step 1: Opening

Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then introduce the purpose and start with the first structure. Superfast!

We've learned that the best way to drain energy is to talk for a long time, to ask everyone to introduce themselves, or to wait for people to drop in.

15 min



Step 2: Clarify The Purpose Of Scrum With 10x10 Writing

To set the stage for everything else, we want to help participants get their collective thinking started about Scrum and their impact. A great way to do this is with the Liberating Structure in-development called [10x10 Writing](#) – or technically 6x6 writing in this case :)

Invitations

"When I think about Scrum, I think about ..."

"What drew me in initially was ..."

"For me, Scrum is all about ..."

"This can be hard because ..."

"If only I ..."

"My hope for the future is that I ... "

Steps

- Ask people to open up a chat window or another space where they can see each other's responses. Explain that you will be sharing sentences for them to complete, one at a time. For each sentence, everyone silently types the first things (one or more) that come to mind *without* hitting send. When you say "Send!", everyone sends in their responses simultaneously.
- **5 min** One by one and going from top to bottom, share the stem of a new sentence for participants to complete. Give participants time to type in their responses (~0.5 to 1 min) and say "Send!".
- **5 min** When the participants have completed all the sentences, ask them to read through everything that appeared. First individually and in silence **2 min** and then notice salient patterns together **3 min**.
- **2 min** If it didn't emerge naturally, clarify that the purpose of the Scrum Framework is all about empiricism. You can use [this visualization](#) or simply put the purpose on a slide. Avoid a lengthy teaching moment; the only thing that matters is that people understand the purpose.

Our Findings

- You can give the example by noticing the first pattern, and then ask what else people noticed while reading through the responses.



Step 3: Explore The Worst Possible Impact With TRIZ

It's all too easy for us to consider only what we're doing well. This easily leads to a blind-spot for all those areas where improvement is possible. The Liberating Structure [TRIZ](#) is an excellent way to illuminate those otherwise dark corners by engaging participants in critical reflection. The purpose of TRIZ is specifically to *stop* ineffective behaviors and not start new ones.

Invitation

"Consider the purpose of Scrum. Now, make a list of all the things you can personally do as a Scrum practitioner, and all the ways you can behave, to actively harm the empirical process and effectively guarantee failure"

Steps

- **3 min** First individually and in silence, ask everyone to compile a list of all the things they can do – personally – to guarantee the worst outcome;
- **5 min** Invite people into pairs and move them into separate breakouts. Here, they share their lists and expand them together. Encourage people to go wild with this one; more is better!;
- **3 min** When everyone is back in the main channel, invite everyone to go over the items they wrote on their lists. This is the moment to invite brutal honesty. Ask: "Go through your list and mark the items that resemble in even the tiniest way something that you're already doing in your own practice".
- **5 min** Invite people into new pairs and move them into separate breakouts. Here, they share what they recognized;
- **3 min** When everyone is back in the main channel, invite everyone to decide what they're going to stop doing from now on. Ask: "Go through the items on your list that you marked. What activities or behaviors will you stop doing from now on to increase your impact with Scrum?"
- **5 min** Invite people into new pairs and move them into separate breakouts. Here, people can share what they are going to stop doing from now on.
- **2 min** When everyone is back in the main channel, you can ask if anyone has anything they feel comfortable sharing with the whole group. What patterns did people notice?

Our Findings

- Invite participants to have fun, go a bit over the top and have a laugh while they're doing it. This helps create a safe environment where people feel comfortable being honest;
- Don't spoil the twist in TRIZ between the first and second rounds. Doing so will limit creativity and the brutal honesty that makes TRIZ work, as people will already start reflecting on their current situation during the first round;
- We purposefully picked pairs instead of small groups. This creates more safety than small groups when it comes to the kinds of personal stories that this application of TRIZ may result in. If you feel there is ample safety in the group, you can also work with groups of four.

Resources

- Blogpost: [Stop counterproductive activities and behaviors to make space for innovation with TRIZ](#)
- The [original article on TRIZ](#) on the Liberating Structures website

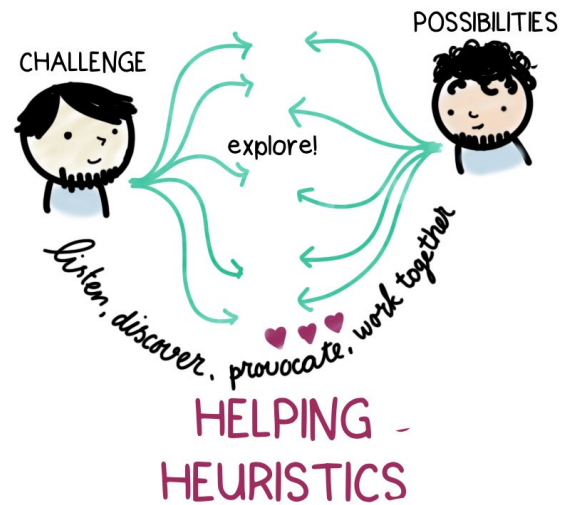


Step 4: Give & Get Help With Helping Heuristics

The previous step has given participants a good insight into where their own actions and behaviors may be limiting their impact with Scrum. The Liberating Structures [Helping Heuristics](#) is a good way to give and get help. It has the added benefit of demonstrating different ways in which people can help each other.

Steps

1. **2 min** First individually and in silence, ask everyone to write down one personal challenge they face with regards to their impact with Scrum. Encourage them to pick something from their TRIZ if possible.
2. **2 min** Explain the sequence of steps, as people will form triads and move into separate breakouts after this. Helping Heuristics consists of three rounds of 15 minutes each. In each round, one participant is the "client", another is the "consultant" and the third is the "observer". Each round consists of four steps, each asking a different method (see "Four Methods" below).
3. **40 min** Invite participants to form groups of three and move them into their separate breakouts. The person with the longest hair becomes the first client, the person with the shortest hair becomes the first observer. The observer helps maintain the timeboxes. As a facilitator, broadcast every now and then what round people should be in.
4. **2 min** When everyone is back in the main channel, debrief what the experience was like. What did people notice about the impact of the various styles on the ability to help clients with their challenges?



Four Methods

- **2 min** In round 1 (**Quiet Presence**), the consultant quietly listens to the challenge as presented by the client. The consultant doesn't interrupt at all.
- **3 min** In round 2 (**Guided Discovery**), the consultant channels his or her inner curiosity to ask all sorts of open-ended questions and help the client better understand their challenge.
- **3 min** In round 3 (**Gentle Provocation**), the consultant interjects advice and gently challenges underlying assumptions to help the client see what they missed before.
- **3 min** In round 4 (**Equal Participation**), the consultant and the client work together to understand the challenge and find potential solutions.
- **3 min** In round 5, the client, observer, and consultant debrief the experience together as well as the impact of the various styles.

Our Findings

- You can also make the observer another consultant. Make sure that one of them keeps track of the time.
- What is helpful to us depends greatly on personal preferences. Sometimes, all you need is the right question. Other times, your underlying assumptions need to be challenged. Or you just need a good example offered to you. Helping Heuristics helps people explore what works best for them.

Resources

- Blogpost: [Practice Progressive Methods For Giving And Getting Helping With Helping Heuristics](#)
- The [original article](#) on the Liberating Structures website

Step 5: Closing



If you have the time, do a quick debrief with the group. A simple Liberating Structure for this is [Impromptu Networking](#) ("What did you observe, think or feel while participating in this meetup?"). Draw out some salient patterns from the whole group, but keep it short.

Make A Group Picture

Take a picture of the whole group (ask for permission). A great way to give energy to an otherwise static picture is to invite people to "say Hi! with a picture" to a Liberator Meetup elsewhere in the world. You can tag them in your message (e.g. "Hi to Liberators in Pittsburgh, US!" or "Hi to Liberators in Bern, Switzerland!"). You can find us on Twitter [here](#).

Closing

Thank everyone for their presence and announce when the next meetup will take place.

After The Meetup



With this string, you should be able to help participants to reflect on their own impact with Scrum. For some, this may have been a wake-up call, for others a confirmation. Either way, we designed this string to create (painful?) transparency, to inspect and adapt – together.

Learn and Grow, Together

If you're stuck with a design or have other questions about this design, reach out to us at info@theliberators.com or other members of the Liberators Support Group. Let's learn and grow, together!

Share Your Outcomes

There is bound to be plenty of learning going on in your session. If you can, please share some of those results with the wider community. We always like to share a collage of pictures (with permission) or a short video. It is a nice way to inspire people to join your meetup, or for other people to start their own in their region.

Try Our Other Strings



This string is part of our [Liberator Network series](#). It probably triggered in-depth conversations, valuable insights, and tangible next steps.

We have many more strings for you to explore with your team, organization, or community! We offer strings to create a strategy, determine your personal impact, and to face your deepest fears! We add new strings every week.

You can find more free and premium strings about our Scrum Mythbusters series [here](#). Or browse all our strings [here](#). Give them a try, and unleash the superpowers of your team, organization, and community!



Unleashing Teams All Over The World

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